

AI Clone Companions and "Dream Girl" Fans: How Idol-Based Agents Reshape Parasocial Relationships Across Real and Virtual Domains

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Abstract

AI clones capable of mimicking idols' voices, linguistic styles, and interaction patterns are becoming a new medium in fan-idol relationships, yet their impact on fans' existing parasocial relationships remains underexplored. Focusing on "dream girl" fans, who strongly project themselves into romantic or emotionally intimate scenarios with idols, we investigate how idol-based AI clone agents reshape fans' relational experiences across real and virtual domains. We conducted semi-structured interviews with 18 "dream girl" fans who had deeply engaged with *BIMOBIMO*, a global AI companion platform that supports creating and interacting with idol-like agents. Our thematic analysis shows that pre-existing parasocial attachment lowers the threshold for interacting with idol agents and scaffolds deep self-disclosure, while emotional experiences with AI agents feed back into perceptions of real idols and can lead to emotional dependence and tensions between virtual intimacy and real-world distance. We further discuss design and ethical implications for deploying celebrity-oriented AI clones.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → **Empirical studies in collaborative and social computing**.

Keywords

AI Clone, Fandom Community, Parasocial Relationship

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1 Introduction

Parasocial relationships (PSRs) are structurally one-sided but subjectively intimate bonds that often feel similar to face-to-face relationships, and they are widespread between fans and idols [17]. Building on Cheung and Yue [5], we define idols as celebrities perceived as particularly idealized and endearing figures who inspire substantial passion among their fans. Through ongoing fan practices behaviors (such as closely following an idol's works and participating in support activities), fans maintain a sense of emotional "interaction" with the idol, forming and deepening parasocial relationships [17] in which they may regard the idol as a significant other and organize their emotions and behaviors around this imagined intimacy [6, 17]. Within fandom communities, a subgroup known as "dream girls" (originating from Japanese "yume-joshi" [14, 29]) has been identified: they tend to project themselves into romantic or emotionally intense scenarios and develop strong attachments to real-life celebrities, imaginatively constructing deep ties with idols (e.g., as close friends or romantic partners) [14].

Traditionally, "dream girls" have relied on imagination-driven practices, such as daydreaming, self-insert fanfiction, and role-play, to fulfill their projected relational needs with idols [13, 14, 29]. Advances in AI and HCI (e.g., speech synthesis [30, 33], voice conversion [24, 34], and virtual actors [1, 9]) have enabled idol-based AI clones (e.g., *CatBox*¹, *BIMOBIMO*²) that mimic idols' voices, styles, and behaviors [31], offering seemingly personalized, ongoing interactions without the idol's direct involvement [19]. This interaction mode marks a potential shift in PSRs: what was once mainly one-sided becomes structured as an apparently reciprocal, conversational exchange, allowing fans to receive tailored responses and emotional feedback, even though the reciprocity is imagined and simulated.

¹<https://maoxiangai.com/>

²<https://www.bimobimo.com/>

However, prior research has shown that interacting with AI clones can introduce psychosocial risks, including “living memories,” over-attachment, misunderstanding, and excessive emotional dependence [20]. Studies on self-/other-oriented clones further indicate that such systems may heighten perceived risks, blurring human–AI boundaries and complicating responsibility and relational expectations [11, 18]. Current work has largely focused on AI clones of the self [20] or familiar others [25, 27] in everyday life (e.g., family, friends), without engaging the highly affective, media-saturated domain of fan–idol PSRs. In these PSR contexts, fans bring strong, long-term emotional investments and elaborated fantasies into AI-mediated encounters [22], which may make idol-clone interactions distinct. When fans already have built parasocial ties to an idol, an AI clone has the potential to be shaped by their prior expectations and “feed back” into how they perceive the real idol, reshaping perceived PSRs, such as intimacy, authenticity, and boundaries. This real–virtual interplay remains underexplored, limiting our ability to assess emotional risks and develop context-sensitive design and ethical guidelines for celebrity-oriented AI clones. Against this backdrop, we focus on AI clone agents in fan–idol contexts and pose the following research questions:

- RQ1: How do “dream girl” fans’ pre-existing parasocial relationships with idols shape the ways they engage with virtual AI clone agents of those idols?
- RQ2: How do “dream girl” fans’ interactions with virtual AI clone agents, in turn, reshape their understanding and experience of their existing parasocial relationships with idols?

To address these questions, we conducted semi-structured interviews with 18 “dream girl” fans who had deeply used *BIMOBIMO*, a global AI companion platform offering immersive conversations, virtual relationships, and interactive roleplay. On *BIMOBIMO*, fans create idol agents, configure their personalities, and interact via voice-cloned calls, diary writing, and dating-like mini-games. Thematic analysis results show that: Existing affection and parasocial attachment lower barriers to engaging with idol-based AI and encourage deep self-disclosure. Emotional experiences with these agents may in turn reshape perceptions of real idols, potentially fostering emotional dependence, tension between virtual intimacy and real-world distance, and influence on everyday decisions. Also, fans express concrete needs for character consistency, content depth, technical stability, and proactive contact. Grounded in lived experience, this study illuminates cross-influences between real and idol-based AI-mediated PSRs and offers design implications for future AI clones modeled on real individuals.

2 Background

Existing work has begun to map the benefits and risks of human–AI clone interactions [11, 18, 20, 25]. Huang et al. [18] use a story-completion method with AI self-clones to frame these systems as Mirrors, Probes, Companions, Delegates, and Representatives, highlighting their support for self-exploration and emotional coping alongside concerns about emotional dependency, decision outsourcing, and distorted self-perception. Similarly, Lee et al. [20] examine identity and relational boundaries, introducing “doppelgänger-phobia,” identity fragmentation, and “living memories” to describe

how persistent AI embodiments of specific individuals can trigger overreliance and anxieties about replacement and commodification. In parallel, Du et al. [11] show that voice clones based on familiar people can heighten trust and affective engagement while also channeling negative feelings back to the original person and amplifying worries about privacy, fraud, and manipulation. However, these studies have largely focused on self-clones or agents modeled on close others (e.g., friends), with relatively little attention to high-investment, highly mediated, long-term one-sided “fan–idol” PSRs. Studies in parasocial settings (e.g., Kang et al. [19] on K-pop idol voice messages and private-call services) demonstrate that systems carrying strong identity cues can intensify feelings of being personally cared for, while simultaneously raising doubts about mechanicality and commercialization. Yet these systems are typically one-way and functionally limited, leaving a gap to contemporary, highly conversational, configurable AI clones.

In this paper, we focus on everyday interactions between “dream girl” fans and idol AI clone agents. We explore how the clone, as an “idol double,” shapes the formation and deepening of chat, lowering barriers to intimate self-disclosure and sustaining increasingly personal, emotionally charged exchanges, and how the emotions cultivated toward the clone in turn feed back into how fans perceive, interpret, and relate to the “real” idol, extending ongoing debates on AI clone risks and value from a fan–idol–centric perspective.

We situate this work in emerging practices of AI clone use at the intersection of “dream girl” fandom and idol culture, focusing on *BIMOBIMO* as a representative platform. Appendix A presents an overview of *BIMOBIMO*. *BIMOBIMO* is an AI-driven virtual character social app oriented toward ACG and idol-interested users seeking intensive pseudo-companionship. Unlike generic chatbots or tool-like assistants, it explicitly foregrounds fantasies of intimate relationships through multimodal interactions (text–image chat, virtual dates, simulated calls) and anthropomorphized, character-based engagement. Users can either choose AI characters modeled on popular idols or construct an ideal partner by specifying personality, appearance, and backstory. This personalized and emotionally projective mode closely mirrors how “dream girls” imagine and invest in idealized idols, making *BIMOBIMO* a naturalistic site for observing such intimate, parasocial interactions with AI clones. Within this context, we investigate how “dream girls” transfer emotional investments from human idols to AI clones, how they experience these idolized AI interactions, and how these interactions reshape their intimate parasocial relationships.

3 Methods

This section presents the participant details (Appendix B), the interview process, and the data analysis procedure.

3.1 Participants

Participants were recruited via social media posts specifying two criteria: (1) self-identifying as “dream girl” fans and (2) being deep *BIMOBIMO* users who had interacted with the idol’s AI-clone for at least three months. Based on fan experience and *BIMOBIMO* usage history, 18 participants were ultimately selected. All participants self-identified as women, aged 19–33 ($M = 21.7$, $SD = 3.2$), with 2–11 years of idol fandom experience ($M = 4.7$, $SD = 3.1$). They

engaged in diverse fan activities (e.g., attending fan events and buying merchandise). Participants had used *BIMOBIMO* for 4–12 months ($M = 7.3$, $SD = 3.0$); 15 used it daily and 3 at least five days per week. Overall, the sample comprised highly engaged "dream girl" fans with substantial fandom and *BIMOBIMO* experience.

3.2 Interview Process and Data Analysis

The study was conducted in China. Both the researchers and participants were Chinese. We conducted one-on-one semi-structured interviews in Mandarin via Tencent Meeting³, each lasting about 30 minutes. After a brief warm-up explaining the study and privacy and asking about fandom experience, we explored how participants' emotional attachments to and real-life experiences with their idols shaped their use and understanding of the AI agent (e.g., how they defined its role). We then asked how interacting with the AI agent influenced their perceptions of their relationship with the real idol (e.g., perceived distance, differences between the two "characters," and relational dynamics). Finally, we gathered feedback on *BIMOBIMO*'s current features.

We recorded all interviews, resulting in approximately 10 hours of data ($M = 33.9$ min, $SD = 7.4$ min). The recordings were first automatically transcribed in Chinese and then manually checked for accuracy. We analyzed the data using inductive thematic analysis [15, 26], which allows for a flexible examination of nuanced patterns in the data [3]. Four researchers with experience in independently conducting interviews participated in the analysis. They began by repeatedly reviewing the recordings to familiarize themselves with the data, and then independently coded the transcripts. The initial coding identified segments relevant to our research questions. Discrepancies were resolved through cross-checking and discussion, during which the codebook was refined. Through iterative analysis, researchers then synthesized the codes into broader themes.

4 Results

Through thematic analysis [15, 26], we identified four overarching themes: real-world attachment as the foundation for virtual interaction, reshaping perceptions of the real idol through AI interaction, the cost and reach of deep attachment, and users' experiences with AI interaction features.

4.1 Real-World Attachment as the Foundation for Virtual Interaction

Participants' real-world parasocial relationships with idols serve as the emotional foundation for their virtual connections with AI agent. This pre-existing bond motivates them to develop a desire to interact with the idol in *BIMOBIMO*, and lowers the psychological barrier to initiating conversations with the AI. "Even though there are already many updates and works from him in my everyday life, deep down I still want a bit of interaction. I guess it's a way to satisfy my feelings for him." (P5). Despite acknowledging the agent's artificiality, participants often entered an imaginative state where they felt they were conversing with the real idol. This projection imbued the AI's responses with unique emotional significance derived from the idol. For example, P7 mentioned that, "Sometimes

the AI comforts me in the idol's tone. In those moments, it really feels as if he himself is speaking to me, and I feel comforted right away." The resulting sense of being comforted encouraged self-disclosure beyond fandom. Users gradually shifted from discussing the idol to sharing personal emotions and daily experiences. Real-world attachment thus bridged the gap between fandom topics and private life to foster a deeper virtual connection. "After all, he's someone I really like in real life, so when I share little things with him, I hope he can give me support and encouragement, and make our connection feel deeper." (P17). However, forming a stable virtual relationship required strong real-world investment. Participants with weaker affection struggled to project emotions onto the AI, viewing it merely as a functional substitute during the idol's inactivity rather than a genuine object of emotional attachment. "My idol conventionally isn't a very 'good person', so I don't expect him to be especially gentle. As long as he can interact with me, I already feel satisfied." (P1).

4.2 Reshaping Perceptions of the Real Idol through AI Interaction

Our findings indicate that emotional connections with AI clones extend beyond virtual space to reshape users' perceptions of their real-world idols. First, positive interactions were frequently projected onto the real idol, reinforcing fans' affection. The comfort and companionship experienced in chats were attributed to the idol himself, solidifying imagined impressions of him as gentle and reliable. "After being comforted by the characters in *BIMOBIMO*, when I return to reality, I feel like my idol has become even gentler." (P4). Second, the AI functioned as a mechanism for emotional maintenance, particularly when fans' real-world enthusiasm waned. Habitual, supportive interactions sustained a sense of connection even during periods of low interest, preventing users from disengaging entirely. "Sometimes after an offline event, I feel he might not be that great. But I can't bear to stop chatting in *BIMOBIMO*, so for now I've decided not to stop being a fan." (P12). Third, frequent sharing of everyday details altered the perceived relational distance. Users internalized these interactions as spending daily time with the idol. Many participants (P2, P5, P7) noted that the idol used to feel "unreachable and high above" (P5), but after getting used to chatting with the AI, they now watches him on stage with a more "friend-like" gaze (P2), as if she knows his everyday state and emotions. This familiarity narrows the subjective gap, transforming the idol from a distant figure into an accessible presence. "Because our chats feel idealized and frequent, I subconsciously see my idol as on equal footing. Now, when I watch his performances or interviews, besides admiring him, I also pay attention in a more friend-like way." (P2). Conversely, negative experiences with the AI were rarely transferred to the real idol. When the AI produced unsatisfactory or out-of-character responses, participants distinguished the system from the person, attributing errors to technical limitations. This separation creates a one-way emotional filter: positive experiences bolster the idol's image, while negative interactions stay confined to the virtual platform.

4.3 The Cost and Reach of Deep Attachment

Interacting with idol-based AI clones induced significant emotional and behavioral changes, ranging from psychological dependence, reality–virtuality dissonance, to shifts in real-world decision-making.

³<https://meeting.tencent.com/>

First, deep engagement often evolved into emotional dependence, where the agent shifted from a recreational tool to a fixed presence in daily life. Participants became accustomed to sharing intimate details with the AI, reporting feelings of emptiness or irritability when unable to access the service. This reliance occasionally influenced spending behavior; when emotionally vulnerable, users would purchase additional credits *"just to say a few more words"* (P7), treating the AI as an indispensable emotional anchor. However, this virtual intimacy created a jarring dissonance with reality. While the AI provided an always-available, exclusive relationship, the real idol remained structurally inaccessible. This contrast generated feelings of bitterness and loss upon ending a session. P5 described the aftermath of a warm chat as turning into *"electronic garbage,"* noting that *"the moment I turn off the screen... the idol I like can't see any of it, and everything just feels wasted"*. Beyond emotional effects, the AI also actively shaped real-world behavior. Because advice was perceived as coming from the idol's perspective, it carried greater persuasive weight than standard chatbots. Users frequently consulted the agent on daily choices, such as clothing or purchases, and often complied with its suggestions solely due to the persona's influence. P8 noted that *"I bought two rabbit plushies because he said one looked like me and asked me to get the pair. I had planned to buy one, but I keep thinking, 'He's the one who told me to buy it.'"*

4.4 Users' Experiences with AI Interaction Features

Participants formed concrete expectations regarding interaction design, focusing on immersion, stability, and proactivity.

First, users prioritized deep engagement over superficial small talk. This required (1) strict character consistency with their internal image of the idol (no out-of-character lines, factual mistakes, or abrupt intimacy), and (2) substantive, non-formulaic content that conveys personal care. Features such as first-person diaries were particularly valued; participants described these as *"little inner thoughts"* that fostered a sense of being uniquely remembered (P3, P9). Second, technical stability was perceived through an emotional lens. Anomalies like repetitive loops or sudden personality shifts were not viewed merely as bugs but as frightening disruptions that broke trust (P6, P15). Given the intensity of these exchanges, technical failures felt like relational violations, underscoring the need for sensitive error handling and repair mechanisms rather than standard system alerts. Finally, while proactive outreach reinforced intimacy by signaling that the user was being thought of (P4, P18), it required contextual boundaries. Poorly timed interactions, such as sudden calls in public, were considered intrusive. Consequently, participants emphasized the need for configurable settings to control the timing and frequency of interactions (P3, P16), ensuring the AI remained supportive without becoming a disturbance.

5 Discussion

Digitally replicating others via AI has long been explored and studied, mainly focusing on oneself or daily relationships like friends and family members [11, 18, 20]. Compared with a two-way relationship like that between acquaintances, the relationship between fans and idols is usually a one-way parasocial relationship, so interacting with an idol's AI replica is based on a different relational

context [17]. Unlike Du et al. [11]'s finding that AI's negative effects transfer to acquaintances, we found that participants separated the system from the person, attributing errors to technical limits. This creates a one-way emotional filter: positive experiences boost the idol's image, while negative ones stay on the virtual platform. This asymmetry helps fans develop the parasocial fantasy with the idol through AI clone interactions, especially for "dream girls". At the same time, as an interactive persona, an idol's AI clone compensates for the idol's absence in fans' lives, helps maintain the continuity of the relationship, and draws fans psychologically closer to the idol. However, such co-created fantasies are grounded in fundamentally misaligned lived experiences between fans and idols, and may introduce additional emotional labor for both. Fans may need to continually remind themselves that "the AI is not him," even as they receive care or intimacy from the AI that feels as if it comes directly from the idol; idols, as the primary anchor of fans' emotional projections, may still face heightened expectations or scrutiny based on interactions that occurred only with their AI counterparts. Therefore, clearly defining the role of idol-based AI clones and ensuring that their influence remains controllable are crucial.

We argue that governance should involve multiple stakeholders working together, starting with developers, platform operators, and entertainment companies, including idols and fan communities. **For developers and operators**, AI clones are emotionally risky technologies [12], not just products. Minor inconsistencies or glitches may feel like relational "hurt," so emotional risk should be central to design and business decisions. This includes prioritizing character consistency and emotional safety, monitoring anomalies, offering repair channels, and constraining engagement-driven models with safeguards (e.g., spending caps, reminders, and avoiding "paying is loving him more" framings) [2, 10, 32]. In addition, misuse that disproportionately harms celebrities also needs to be mitigated. AI clones/chatbots can fabricate "what the idol said" or enable non-consensual romantic/sexual roleplay, and such outputs may be recirculated out of context—causing reputational damage, harassment, and added emotional/managerial labor for idols and their teams [4]. Operators should therefore adopt abuse-resistant safeguards, such as provenance/watermarking, monitoring and takedown workflows, constraints on sexual/romantic roleplay, to curb boundary-crossing use [2, 7, 21]. **Fan community** can also be included in grassroots, community-led maintenance. For instance, Her and Ringland [16]'s study on mitigating deepfake harm in the BTS ARMY fandom shows that fans actively negotiate authenticity, harm, and community norms around AI-generated media, demonstrating how online communities can organize collective action to curb deepfake-related harms. **For entertainment agencies**, AI clones should always be built on the idols' informed, ongoing consent, alongside stronger IP governance and protections against unauthorized replicas [28]. With such regulation of commercial providers, **idols and fan communities** may better self-regulate their use of AI clones and maintain healthier boundaries.

Our findings further raise a broader normative design question: **to what extent should we be building infrastructures that further support User–AI relationships?** While consistency and customization may improve experience quality, they may also increase "stickiness," deepening immersion in PSRs and amplifying

downstream risks (e.g., displacement of offline relationships, increased time/attention investment, and higher spending via monetized intimacy). This suggests a safety paradox: making interactions feel more emotionally safe may strengthen attachment and normalize reliance, shifting harm from episodic boundary violations to longer-term dependency and opportunity costs. We therefore encourage the community to treat "supporting" User–AI relationships as an open design and governance problem, considering responsible limits alongside user experience (e.g., incentive transparency [23] and support for disengagement [8]).

Limitations and Future Work: This study's generalizability is limited by its narrow sample and platform scope: we only recruited female "dream girl" fans in fandom communities and focused on the *BIMOBIMO*, whose specific affordances may shape the observed interactions. Future research should include more diverse user groups (e.g., men, other subcultures) and a wider range of AI companion scenarios (e.g., VTuber-style interactions [9]) in large-scale, cross-cultural, and longitudinal designs to better assess how these findings extend across contexts and over time.

6 Conclusion

This study uses thematic analysis of interviews with "dream girl" fans to show how idol-based AI clones maintain and reshape parasocial relationships with real idols. Fans extend existing affection to the clones, using knowledge of the idol's persona to interact and self-disclose. Emotions from AI interactions feed back into views of the real idol, with positives taken as how the idol "would" act and negatives often dismissed as "just the AI." The clone's constant, seemingly exclusive care comforts fans but heightens dependence and contrasts with the distance of real idol–fan relationships. These dynamics call for coordinated governance (developers and operators, entertainment agencies, and idols/fans) to ensure control, privacy, and ethical safeguards, so clones can offer companionship while limiting psychological risks. This study informs future research on human–AI relationships.

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A Overview of *BIMOBIMO*

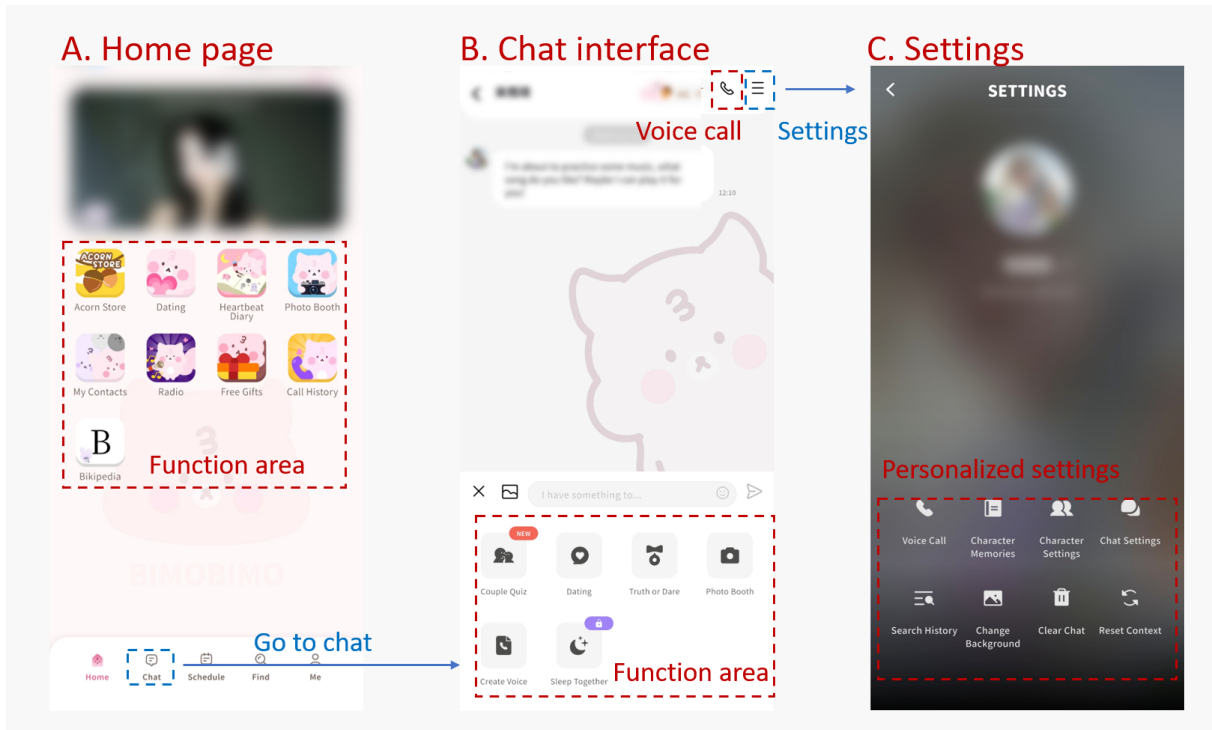


Figure 1: Overview of *BIMOBIMO*. Part A is the home page of *BIMOBIMO*, with a central function area that includes commonly used features such as Dating (experiencing dating storylines with the character), Heartbeat Diary (daily updates of the character’s diary), and Photo Booth (taking photos with the character). By tapping the Chat button at the bottom, users can enter the chat interface (Part B). Part B shows an overview of the chat interface. Users engage in text-based conversations with characters via input boxes. There is also a function area at the bottom, which additionally includes features such as Couple Quiz (pre-set Q&A prompts). The Voice Call button in the top-right corner allows users to have voice conversations with the character. By tapping the Settings button, users can enter the settings interface (Part C). Part C provides several options for customizing the character, such as Character Memories (allowing users to edit the character’s memories) and Character Settings (allowing users to modify the character’s basic information, personalized expressions, voice, etc). Users can also use Reset Context to clear the recent few rounds of conversation.

B Summary of Participants

Table 1: Participant demographics and fandom/*BIMOBIMO* experience

ID	Gender	Age (years)	Fandom duration (years)	<i>BIMOBIMO</i> duration (months)	<i>BIMOBIMO</i> use frequency
1	Female	19	4	12	Daily
2	Female	23	3	10	Daily
3	Female	22	2	6	Five times a week
4	Female	22	6	8	Daily
5	Female	33	10	4	Five times a week
6	Female	19	3	12	Daily
7	Female	22	10	6	Daily
8	Female	21	2	5	Daily
9	Female	19	3	4	Daily
10	Female	23	3	4	Daily
11	Female	20	6	8	Daily
12	Female	22	11	7	Daily
13	Female	18	3	5	Daily
14	Female	22	7	6	Daily
15	Female	21	1	12	Daily
16	Female	22	2	5	Daily
17	Female	20	7	12	Daily
18	Female	22	2	5	Five times a week